Broussard: "We always ask, very consciously, with every movie we make: Why do audiences need to go back to see this movie? What are we giving them that's different, that's fresh? With *Iron Man 3*, that began with the choice of a new filmmaker, putting Shane Black in the director's chair. We knew it would stamp this as something different than what they'd seen before."

"To me," Black says, "it's about capturing and doubling the intensity that *The Avengers* managed to capture. We're trying to get as much into this film as we can, to get a ton of thrills in a short space and make a nice little stew."

With a new director at the helm, the studio faced yet another balancing act: keeping the series fresh, while remaining faithful to the vision of the first two films.

"Clearly, as a storyteller, Shane Black had his take," says Victoria Alonso, Executive Producer of *Iron Man 3* and EVP of VFX and Post Production. "Shane of course brought his vision to the story, and contributed to the look of it. But as far as the look of the suits and the look of what Iron Man's style is, we had it pretty well established in other movies. So we tried to stay respectful to what we had done before."

Even as the filmmakers threw Tony Stark back—metaphorically—into that cave in Afghanistan, they themselves reached back to a graphic novel that had already provided crucial inspiration: Warren Ellis and Adi Granov's pivotal Iron Man story, *Extremis*.

Iron Man was created in 1963, in a story for the anthology series *Tales of Suspense*. Stan Lee, the father of Marvel Comics, plotted the story around a costume design and cover by legendary artist Jack Kirby. Lee's brother, writer Larry Lieber, then scripted it over artwork by Don Heck.

The initial origin, heavily influenced by Cold War politics, featured munitions manufacturer Tony Stark, who is captured by enemy soldiers while on a tour of Vietnam and forced to build them a weapon.

Stan Lee describes his creation of the character: "He's an inventor. He's a multimillionaire. He's good looking. He likes the women...but there should be something tragic about him. And then it occurred to me if somehow, when he got his iron armor, he gets into a fight, and he gets injured in his chest. And his heart is injured, and he has to wear this little thing that runs the iron armor. He has to wear that on his chest because it also keeps his heart beating. And that would make him a tragic figure as well as the most powerful guy. So I thought the readers would like him even more with that little bit added to it."

In 2004, Marvel Comics called on Warren Ellis and Adi Granov to update and revise the Iron Man character. Ellis made several crucial changes, including moving the origin to Afghanistan and replacing the Cold War villains with modern terrorists. He also added a deeper political awareness to Tony Stark, heightening the character's sense of guilt over the many deaths



Iron Patriot from the variant cover to *Dark Avengers (2009) #1* by Marko Djurdjevic.